

Beliefs are inevitable. Every individual that lived in any period of time had some kind of belief, either in certain gods, themselves, or knowledgeable facts. Even ancient humans during the Paleolithic period had beliefs such as the god of fire or other nature-related beliefs defined as totemism. There were also beliefs about death, weather, etc. as to how to define special phenomena.

Beliefs can be defined as "a principle, proposition, idea, or something accepted as true." This includes religious beliefs such as Christianity or Buddhism and ideas like "an apple a day keeps the doctor away." So, there are many different types of beliefs. And in order to categorize these beliefs, they will be divided into three categories: individual, other individuals, and the surrounding world or environment.

To consider whether beliefs are voluntary, it is necessary to define what is "voluntary" and what isn't. The word voluntary is described as something being performed, undertaken, or brought about by free choice, willingly, or without being asked. In terms of voluntary beliefs, it means a belief that an individual has formed within himself or herself without being influenced by others or the surrounding environment. On the other hand, involuntary beliefs are beliefs affected by others and situations. In this essay, I will explain the psychological behaviors and theories that narrate how beliefs are involuntary.

Beliefs are involuntary, according to the psychology behind them. Beliefs were made mostly to survive when they were first introduced to humans, finding patterns between different events and suggesting what would happen next. For example, our ancestors could relate the color of the water to its toxicity to avoid getting sick. This pinpoints the idea that humans were forced to form beliefs about related events to prevent and predict what would happen, making assumptions based on visual evidence. However, this creates many errors in beliefs by having the brain think of a belief first and then support it with biased evidence.

In modern times, beliefs are heavily influenced by conformity too. Conformity has enough power to alter or even create an individual's thoughts or beliefs without explanations or facts. An example of this can be found in the Solomon Asch conformity experiment. Asch's experiment was an experiment to witness the power of conformity, with 50 test subjects believing the experiment was a "vision test". But the real experiment was to put in one test subject with seven other confederates, believed to be the same participants by the test subjects. The process of the experiment required the test subjects to pick the longest line when asked to choose the longest line out of three lines, which was very obvious. However, the key to this experiment was that the seven confederates would say the wrong answer in 12 out of 18 trials. Surprisingly, about a third of the test subjects conformed to the confederates and chose the wrong answer 12 times, with 75% of participants conforming at least once.

The evidence drawn from the experiment clearly showed how humans tend to conform to the power of the group rather than believing in facts or what they see. In terms of beliefs, conformity can also be applied psychologically if the surroundings of an individual are all believing in prevalent or parallel idea(s), which can cause the individual to also believe in the

belief, even if it isn't true or morally wrong. The power of conformity is able to make beliefs involuntary, which can be enforced by the sheer power of the surrounding environment.

Another way the environment can affect an individual's beliefs is through grooming. This does not mean grooming in terms of sexual abuse of children, but rather persuading or educating people about an ideology and making them believe in it. Such an example would be about gender identity. In recent years, there have been many proponents who believe that there are more genders than the traditional male and female. However, the new idea of having over 100 genders has also become a controversial belief, as people are fighting to "identify" as their idealistic gender while disregarding the biology and physical attributes they were naturally born with. With the successful movement of the community, social media and educational organizations have been grooming and prospering gender identity campaigns without any consent. This is a type of advocacy education program, as it somewhat teaches the ideology that there can be limitless genders rather than respecting everybody's opinion on the idea. Recent conflicts and outrage saw the BBC's controversial '100 Genders video taken down due to its inappropriate content. This video was intended to educate children about gender identity and included the idea that people don't need to be cisgendered. The video triggered outbursts of various opinions but ultimately confused children about their gender identity, resulting in the BBC retracting their video.

Children are vulnerable to ideas that adults tell them, like parents or teachers. The words of adults heavily influence young people's beliefs. This is because the younger generation tends to believe the older generation because they have lived longer and are thus wiser. This is not always the case, but this way of passing knowledge down has been repeated for a long time and has become a tradition. These can be religions or political viewpoints passed down by parents. Research conducted in 2010 showed that about half of the parents and their children shared the same religious beliefs, which is quite a majority. And about forty percent of parents say that they have at least some similar beliefs as their children. Although this is only due to religious belief, it has a significant meaning that shows children are heavily affected by close adults.

Personality traits such as cultural background, ethnicity, and personal conditions make beliefs involuntary as they significantly impact one's choices and beliefs. For instance, older people tend to believe more in religion. This is because as they get older, the fear of death pressures them more to seek comfort. And since they're afraid of death, they'll be more reliant on religion, which provides them with the feeling of comfort and peace that they'll go to a better place after death. The number of beliefs a person could have is infinite. Some might think that gods don't exist, while others do. However, what shapes these beliefs is all up to our surroundings rather than one's choice or will to believe in something.

Another example of disregarding religion can be political beliefs. In particular, in America, a wealthier person might likely follow the ways of the Republican Party. As their policies are related to lower taxes, free-market principles, and limited government, which is what a wealthier person would like, as they would like a lesser tax as they earn very much, and free-market as they are getting benefits from the current market system. However, a relatively poor person or a

good samaritan will likely believe in Democrats. This is because their policies focus on social equality and economic opportunities, which will be great for the mentioned group of people, as they want them or others to be wealthier and equal to others.

As previously mentioned, the 25% of participants who did not conform to others in the Solomon Asch conformity experiment can provide more insight into how individualism reflects involuntary actions. Their voluntariness of beliefs is affected by their lifestyle and personality, which were formed throughout their lives. And as a result of these examples, humans are designed to pick or hope for what is beneficial for them, not others.

From an evolutionary point of view, beliefs are necessary for humanity to survive. We need to predict and come up with beliefs about the surrounding environment so that we can live in the safety of our thoughts. This was also passed down until modern times, with beliefs making people live in a structured society with ease and without conflict. Humans, who have very individualistic traits, know what is good for them unconsciously. Conformity contributes to this, as people instinctively follow others rather than being an outlier to feel safe and accepted. Grooming, however, is wrongly taking advantage of the belief that adults are smarter than kids and making kids believe in opinions, not facts.

To sum up, the beliefs of humans come entirely from the environment surrounding them, regardless of any arguments. The personality traits of one also derive from their environment, as if their neighbors are strict or kind. Even if genetics or other birth-decided factors can give a congenital preference for beliefs or personality, that is mostly false, and even if it does, it is until an individual isn't able to develop beliefs.

Beliefs may seem totally dependent on an individual's mindset or personal behavior, but they are totally dependent on their surroundings, whether it is about God, another person's impression, or yourself.